

THE CHINESE COMMUNIST PARTY'S LAYERED ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE STRATEGY

JULY 21, 2025



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I. Executive Summary

The People's Republic of China (PRC) has developed a coherent, centralized AI strategy to serve its national ambitions for economic modernization, global influence, and internal governance. The overarching strategy is a composite of overlapping plans, including the New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan (NGAIDP),¹ Digital China,² and the Cyber Sovereignty doctrine.³ AI is at the core of the Chinese Communist Party's (CPC) vision for technological self-reliance and state security.⁴

This brief outlines how the PRC combines industrial policy, ideological oversight, and data-driven central planning to advance AI. China's current push for AI dominance leverages decades of CPC policy development to produce "indigenous" design collaboration across military, commercial, and academic research. Its plans create digital platforms in commerce, finance, and communications nationwide to collect data and integrate AI, and harness the advantages of its designated "national champions" to efficiently produce computer chips, self-driving electric vehicles, batteries, and rare earth minerals.

Despite the clear advantages of China's centralized planning and top-down execution in AI development, its layered strategy creates internal contradictions that at times hinder progress. While the CPC retains firm ideological control over the direction and purpose of AI deployment, the actual implementation of policies occurs across a sprawling and often disjointed bureaucratic system. This complexity is not incidental; it is a structural feature of China's governance model, where overlapping mandates, local experimentation, and interagency competition coexist with national strategies and political doctrines. However, regional managers' short-term political calculations can trump longer term technological advancement and commercial innovations. Additionally, The Cyberspace Administration of China (CAC) requires all actors to align AI design with "core socialist values," which means that AI design, and even the type of raw data collected, is shaped to comply with political sensitivities. Understanding these institutional

¹ State Council of the PRC. (2017). New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan. http://www.gov.cn/zhengce/content/2017-07/20/content_5211996.htm

² Cyberspace Administration of China. (2017). Digital China Strategy Outline.

³ State Council Information Office. (2010s). China's Policies and Actions on Cyber Sovereignty.

frictions is essential to grasping both the strengths and the vulnerabilities of China's AI trajectory.

II. Key Takeaways

- China's AI strategy is built and layered atop decades of ideological and institutional planning. From Deng Xiaoping's reform era to Xi Jinping's digital governance, AI has been folded into evolving doctrines of modernization, centralization, and techno-political control, rather than developed as a discrete or standalone policy initiative.
- The CPC sees AI as a strategic asset to reinforce, not disrupt, Party dominance. AI is embedded in national governance as both an industrial tool and an ideological instrument, used for surveillance, censorship, and "social governance" purposes that align with core Party interests.
- This brief consolidates, in one place, the full scope of CPC policies guiding AI development. It offers an accessible mapping of national strategies, historical context, and institutional actors, providing a foundation for understanding how AI fits into China's broader goals of state control, global competitiveness, and innovative government.

III. The Layers of China's AI Ideologies

China's strategic advantage in artificial intelligence is the product of a carefully structured ideological and institutional progression, deliberately engineered by the CPC to transform technology into a pillar of national power while maintaining their authority. The CPC's approach to AI is both technical and profoundly political, rooted in a vision that fuses Party legitimacy with technological self-sufficiency and global influence. This ideological progression reveals how the CPC has strategically aligned its technological vision with its political doctrine. By periodically reviewing AI's development and progress—and issuing new conceptual foundations to adjust course as needed and to drive adoption/execution of new technology—the party builds each phase logically on the one before, integrating new developments and transforming abstract political goals into enforceable policies, legal mechanisms, and tangible infrastructure projects.

Foundational Layer (1991-2000): From Class Struggle to Tech-Driven Legitimacy

In the Foundational Layer, China pivoted its ideology from a communist, proletariat focus to an embrace of markets and technological innovation. Following international isolation after the crackdown at Tiananmen Square, the collapse of the Soviet Union, and U.S. dominance in the first Gulf War, Deng Xiaoping led the CPC in a new direction towards markets, international trade, and indigenous technological development, beginning with the "Socialism with Chinese

Characteristics” plan (中国特色社会主义市场经济). This allowed the Party to reassert political control while promoting economic growth through state-led markets and innovation.

The CPC’s embrace of “scientific development” and promotion of “tech self-reliance” legitimized its authority over market-led innovation pathways, culminating in Jiang Zemin’s “Three Represents” (三个代表) doctrine, which redefined the Party’s base to include private entrepreneurs, scientists, and technocrats. This created the foundation for China’s centralization of state, military, academic, and business resources in the development of AI by asserting Party preeminence over market processes and emerging technologies.

This ideological and political transformation laid the bedrock for China’s AI strategy: It embedded science and technology advancement within the CPC’s political identity and made state-led innovation—not private entrepreneurship or liberal markets—the dominant model for national development. Without this foundational shift, China’s current techno-political AI agenda would be inconceivable.

Driver	How It Set the Stage
中国特色社会主义市场经济 (<i>Socialism with Chinese Characteristics</i> , 1992)	Introduced the model of state-directed markets, allowing for entrepreneurship alongside state-led tech investment and Party control over innovation paths. Allows China to cultivate “national champions” within the private sector and create state-operated enterprises (SOE) that become central to China’s commercial AI development.
科教兴国战略 (<i>Strategy for Revitalization of the Nation through Science and Education</i> , 1995)	Invested in universities to develop world-class science and technology research, established major funding for basic research, and revitalized 1980s-era applied technology projects to focus on domestic innovation in academia.
三个代表 (<i>Three Represents</i> , 2000)	Pivoted CPC ideology and membership away from its earlier focus on Marxist/Maoist working class representation to now include elites in business, science and technology, cementing the model of centrally coordinated academia, business, and government sectors.

Strategic Integration Layer (2000-2012): Localized Competition, Nationalized Ambition

China's rapid economic development in the late 1990s and early 2000s was centrally authorized but largely implemented at a local level. Much like the light manufacturing boom, research and development in advanced computing was driven by competition among private companies and academic institutions, fueled by provincial political patrons and international companies eager to invest in China. China opened its private companies and SOEs to massive international collaborations and technology transfers, with foreign firms competing against each other to secure access to Chinese labor and markets. Beijing welcomed this dynamism while guiding it through state planning and joint ventures. Crucially, this era saw the formal linkage of technology with national security, under frameworks like Military-Civil Fusion (MCF) and the Strategic Emerging Industries Initiative. These plans began treating emerging “frontier” technologies—which AI would later become—as instruments of power and regime preservation.

This phase institutionalized the strategic fusion of technology and governance, which would later embed AI development within China's national security calculus. Today's centralized control over AI stems from this period of local experimentation, regulatory scaffolding, and growing People's Liberation Army (PLA) involvement, all of which enabled the Party to later consolidate these efforts into a unified national AI project.

Driver	How It Built on the Foundational Layer
引进–消化–吸收–再创新 (<i>Import–Digest–Absorb–Re-Innovate</i>) (2006)	Formalized in the 2006 MLP, this built the justification for importing, copying, and eventually replacing foreign tech. Laid groundwork for “Made in China 2025” (MIC2025) and AI infrastructure.
军民融合 (<i>Military-Civil Fusion</i>) (2007, 2015)	Extended the “tech-for-national-strength” concept into the security domain, enabling dual-use AI (e.g., vision, natural language processing). Tied innovation to national power.
战略性新兴产业 (<i>Strategic Emerging Industries Initiative</i>) (2010)	Codified the goal of dominating emerging tech sectors. Became the ideological core of MIC2025 and NGAIDP. Operationalizes tech self-reliance in global competition.

Social Framing Layer (2012–2017): Ideological Infrastructure for Digital Control

The Social Framing Layer added ideas of “revival” and “social transformation” to the political narrative surrounding AI. Emerging technologies began to be framed as instruments for China’s national rejuvenation and governance modernization. While China had not yet achieved advanced AI capability, it constructed the ideological and infrastructural base necessary for eventual deployment. Programs like Skynet and Sharp Eyes, Smart Cities, and the Social Credit System created both justification and pipelines for surveillance, data collection, and algorithmic governance. These were not afterthoughts or disconnected projects; they were proof of concept for how digital tools could serve the Party’s ambitions of societal control, even before machine learning had matured.

This layer proved that the CPC was not waiting for AI breakthroughs, but rather shaping the ecosystem that would make them politically useful in advance. The CPC went beyond building just the technical capacity for AI, creating the political logic for it to become an extension of centralized rule as well. The collection, classification, and politicization of mass data were always intended as precursors to AI deployment.

Driver	How It Reinforced Earlier Themes
民族复兴 / 中国梦 (<i>National Rejuvenation / China Dream</i>) (2012)	Politically-framed emerging technology, and especially AI, as tools for civilizational revival. Justified accelerating investment and competition with the U.S.
国家治理现代化 (<i>Governance Modernization</i>) (2013)	Promoted the integration of digital technologies, like AI, beyond industry and security into state operations. Laid the foundation for smart cities, algorithmic governance, and digitized bureaucracy.
国家安全观 (<i>Comprehensive National Security</i>) (2014)	Expanded national security issues to include cyber, data, and AI, reinforcing the need for MCF. Legitimized the emerging AI infrastructure as a tool for surveillance and control.

Operationalization Layer (2017–2025): Turning Doctrine into Scalable AI Deployment

Finally, the Operationalization Layer translated decades of ideological commitments and strategic planning into reality, applying actual AI capabilities to the vast data systems constructed in earlier phases. This marked a critical turning point: AI was no longer merely a rhetorical

device or long-term development goal, but now being implemented across state functions, industrial systems, and mechanisms of societal governance. Crucially, it was during this layer that maturing AI technologies, especially machine learning and neural networks, began to be integrated at scale into China’s Big Data architecture, from surveillance networks and social credit systems to smart cities and predictive policing.

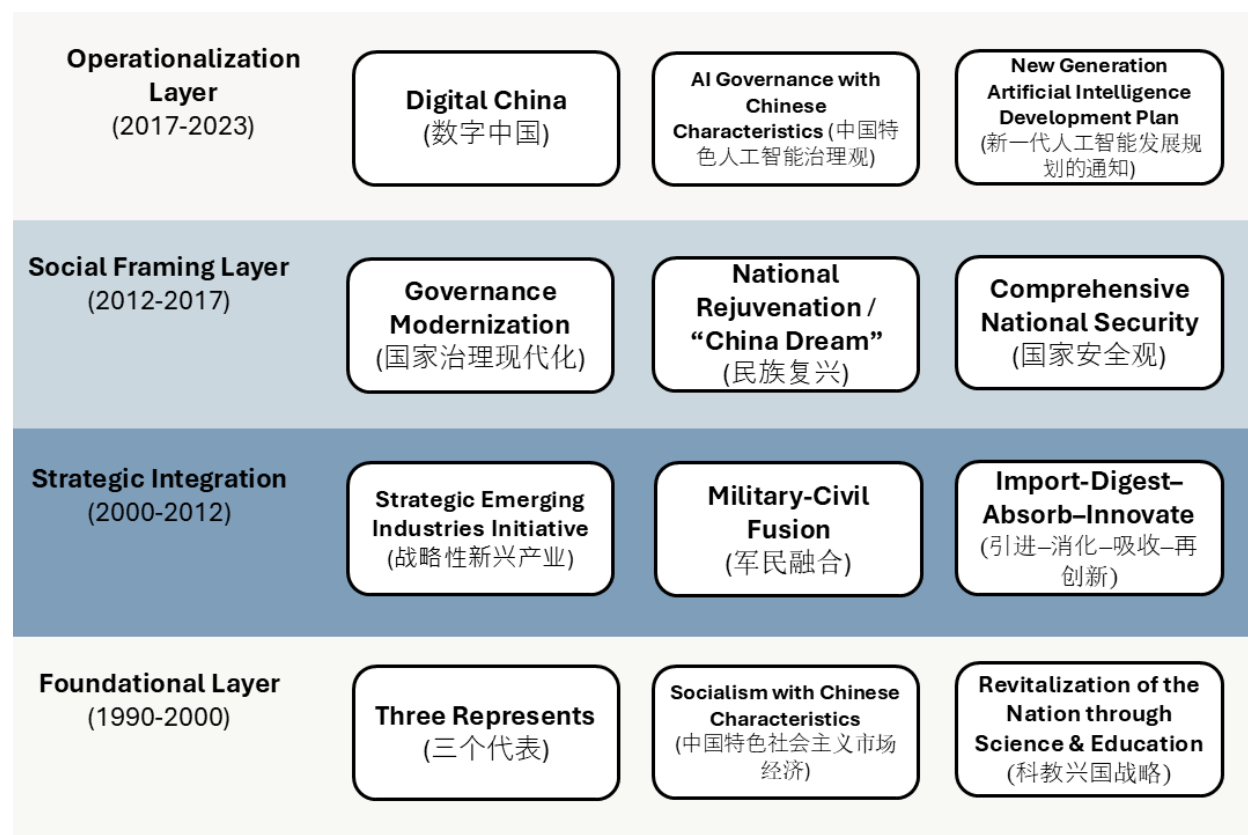
This is where the previously constructed scaffolding came to life. The ideological vision from the Foundational Layer, the national coordination from the Strategic Integration Layer, and the narrative and infrastructure from the Social Framing Layer all converged to enable AI to function as the CPC’s ultimate tool of digital statecraft. The Party’s control over data, institutions, and narrative ensured that AI would enhance political stability and central authority rather than disrupting it.

Driver	How It Activated Earlier Ideologies
新一代人工智能发展规划的通知 (<i>New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan</i>) (2017)	Synthesizes socialist control ideologies with modern high-tech competitive realities. Establishes goals for AI to be centrally coordinated through the socialist system, but market-dominant and open-source to assure global reach.
中国特色人工智能治理观 (<i>AI Governance with Chinese Characteristics</i>) (2019)	Applied governance modernization and national security logic to algorithmic control, censorship, and ethical frameworks. Regulates AI outcomes and narrative power.
数字中国建设整体布局规划 (<i>Plan for the Overall Layout of Building a Digital China</i>) (2023)	Outlines China’s digitalization strategy, emphasizing digital infrastructure, data resources, and integration with the “Five-Sphere Integrated Plan”: concerning digital government, digital politics, digital culture, digital society, and digital ecology.

IV. Feedback Governance: How Ideology Becomes Infrastructure

The CPC’s approach to AI governance is sustained not just by top-down directives, but by a self-reinforcing system of ideological and bureaucratic feedback loops. These loops ensure that political doctrine does not remain abstract, but is continuously translated into concrete policy actions, institutional mandates, and technological deployment. Core ideologies such as Tech Self-Reliance activate entire chains of bureaucratic execution—triggering legal reforms, funding streams, and regulatory controls that prioritize AI in national planning. The accompanying flow chart illustrates how key interlinked ideologies compound one another: Foundational concepts like “Socialism with Chinese Characteristics” legitimize long-term state leadership in

technology, while national security doctrines enable the proliferation of surveillance AI and dual-use platforms. This cyclical process allows the CPC to reinforce its strategic control over AI development while adjusting implementation to deal with evolving geopolitical, economic, and technological conditions.⁴



This progression demonstrates how China's AI advantage is both intentional in design and emergent in effect. Formulated as a set of top-down ideological declarations, policies evolved into a dynamic ecosystem in which ideology, institutions, and infrastructure reinforce one another in a continuous feedback loop. National security doctrines activate bureaucratic execution. Digital platforms and data systems transform these doctrines into operational tools. Academic institutions and government agencies develop competing policies and lobby for the central government to adopt them in CPC 5-year plans and policy pronouncements. And when conditions shift, geopolitically or technologically, the CPC can adjust course without loosening its grip. In contrast to more fragmented democratic systems, where innovation often outpaces

⁴ CSIS. (2020). Decoding China's AI Strategy.

regulation or ideological consensus, the PRC has created a model of mission-oriented governance that is uniquely equipped to pursue long-term, strategic goals in AI.

This system is not without its contradictions: its centralized rigidity stifles creativity; political advantage can trump efficiency and technical excellence; and its opacity complicates global engagement. But as an engine of national coordination and industrial alignment, it offers a formidable advantage, engineered from ideology and refined through years of strategic adaptation.

V. Ideological Engineering and Social Control: The Political Architecture of AI in China

AI in China has been shaped by ideological doctrine and engineered to serve the CPC's core objective: maintaining and projecting Party control over society. While much of China's early AI development lacked mature technical capacity, it laid a deep ideological and institutional foundation that continues to shape how AI is designed, deployed, and regulated today. These early efforts may appear to be merely historical; however, they remain deeply relevant. They established the operational ethos for AI as a tool of authoritarian governance.

China's AI ecosystem is a product of ideological engineering, where political values are embedded directly into technical design. The Party does not treat AI as neutral infrastructure, but as an instrument of governance and a vehicle for national rejuvenation. Through legal mandates, bureaucratic planning, and algorithmic governance, the CPC has ensured that digital technologies reinforce the Party's ideological narratives and state authority.⁵ Ideological engineering allows abstract principles like national rejuvenation or social harmony to become operationalized in surveillance systems, data architectures, and predictive governance models. It reflects the Party's conviction that technological infrastructure should not only serve state functions but also sustain and project the CPC's power across every layer of China's digital strategy.⁶

The centrality of the CPC's authority in technology development—and the origins of this model—can be traced back to Jiang Zemin's "Three Represents." This pronouncement expanded the Party's policy interests to include not just workers and peasants, but also private entrepreneurs, technocrats, and the scientific elite. This paved the way for the CPC's involvement in shaping the digital economy and emerging tools, not as observers, but as active designers. By "representing the advanced productive forces," the Party opened space for its own role in digital industry and private tech development. "Representing advanced culture" justified

⁵ Sacks, Samm. "Beijing Wants to Define How the Global Internet Works." *Foreign Affairs*, 2019.

⁶ Triolo, Paul, et al. *The New China Rules: How the Country Is Standardizing Artificial Intelligence*. Eurasia Group, 2020.

the CPC's guidance over moral and digital life, and "representing the overwhelming majority of the people" reframed authoritarian control as social harmony. Another key part of this ideological shift was a recognition that the CCP needed to embrace Western economic and scientific innovations to develop and compete with the West, while retaining control over all levers of power in Chinese society.

As these policies evolved, the Party's frameworks for economic development and societal control merged, with AI becoming perhaps the strongest example. Today, this is visible in the Party's deployment of "AI with Chinese Characteristics," a framework that embeds Marxist-Leninist values into algorithmic systems and regulatory structures.⁷ Algorithms are governed to reflect Party doctrine, particularly in areas such as content moderation, algorithmic censorship, and social credit enforcement, where regulatory guidelines explicitly require alignment with "Core Socialist Values."⁸ The CPC views AI as an essential pillar in achieving long-term strategic objectives like National Rejuvenation, Comprehensive National Security, and Governance Modernization. AI deployment supports these ideologies as they shape institutional behavior through funding streams, legal mandates, and infrastructure planning, reinforcing Party rule and enhancing China's global standing while increasingly automating political enforcement.⁹

Chinese social policies have in turn begun to contribute to their AI strategy as well. By the mid-2010s, AI algorithms were employed to detect and filter content based on keywords and patterns associated with prohibited topics, such as political dissent or criticism of the CPC. These systems could rapidly identify and suppress undesirable content across various platforms, significantly reducing the reliance on human censors. Beyond content moderation, AI played a pivotal role in enhancing China's surveillance capabilities. The integration of AI with facial recognition technology enabled the development of sophisticated monitoring systems capable of identifying and tracking individuals in real time. Projects like "Skynet" (天网工程) exemplify this control architecture. These are not only technical surveillance systems, but also reflections of a governance philosophy where visibility equals authority. AI is applied to vast data ecosystems including public camera networks, online platforms, and social services. These do not simply optimize public administration but automate loyalty and preempt dissent. These systems function as the CPC's eyes and ears, continuously scanning society for compliance.

This political layering is rooted in Party ideology and realized through technical governance. Fully appreciating this dynamic is essential for understanding how China uses AI to centralize

⁷ Leung, Amy. AI with Chinese Characteristics: Beijing's Model of Algorithmic Governance. MERICS, 2022.

⁸ Webster, Graham, et al. Translation: China's "Generative AI Measures" (2023). DigiChina, Stanford University.

⁹ Kania, Elsa. In Military-Civil Fusion, China Is Learning Lessons from the United States. CNAS, 2019.

and automate its social control systems. Far from historical background, it is the operating system of Chinese AI governance today.

VI. Data As The Linchpin of Economic Strategy and Authoritarian Control

The CPC has positioned data as the core economic and governance asset of China's AI development, shifting focus from political framing to data itself. It is both the fuel for economic modernization and the infrastructure of societal control. The CPC's strategic emphasis on data illuminates how China's AI model is not only about innovation; it is also about ownership, control, and governance through information.

In 2020, at the Fifth Plenum of the 19th Central Committee, the Chinese Communist Party officially declared data a “factor of production” on par with labor, land, capital, and technology. This was not just economic policy but a larger shift. Data is not just an input in China's AI model, it is a central asset of national power and strategic governance.¹⁰ Under China's National Data Strategy, information is centralized, securitized, and mobilized for national development and Party authority. The CPC views data as a sovereign resource, not a market commodity.

Mandatory data-sharing regulations compel platform companies to contribute to national AI objectives and development. Datasets are shared across industries and sectors, curated for national AI development. This structure reflects a vision where data is controlled, securitized, and optimized for CPC-defined outcomes. In short, data in the CPC's strategic framework is not merely a technical input but a lever of centralized control, digital authoritarianism, and strategic statecraft in the AI age.

The result is a vertically integrated pipeline, where behavioral, biometric, and transactional data is extracted from smart cities, social platforms, healthcare systems, and finance, then curated for AI modeling and governance. The National Data Strategy, Data Security Law,¹¹ and Personal Information Protection Law form a legal triad that codifies centralized data control, access, and monetization. These laws are administered primarily through the CAC and the National Data Bureau and National Data Administration (NDB/NDA) which share overlapping roles: regulating digital platforms and ensuring data use reflects CPC ideological alignment. As the DigiChina project at Stanford notes, China's data regime is not merely regulatory, it is “a wider strategic vision of cyber-sovereignty and Party control.”¹²

This vision finds physical expression in smart cities, digital infrastructure, and surveillance ecosystems, which act as perpetual data extraction hubs. Enabled by deep integration between SOEs and private technology platforms, these systems capture real-time behavioral, biometric,

¹⁰ Cheung, Tai Ming. China's AI Development: Political Vision and Strategic Frictions. UC Institute on Global Conflict and Cooperation, 2021.

¹¹ CAC. (2020). Data Security Law and Cross-border Data Flow Rules.

¹² Creemers, Rogier, et al. China's Emerging Data Governance System. DigiChina, Stanford University, 2021.

and transactional data across urban environments. Whether gathered through facial recognition, license plate tracking, or algorithmic risk scoring, the data supports both AI model development and political enforcement.¹³ These capabilities ensure even private actors operate under state discipline.

But this system is not without risk. The very systems of censorship and propaganda that the CPC uses to maintain its social cohesion have historically led to self-censorship and misreporting of data. Researchers have found that models trained on censored data exhibited significant biases, associating “democracy” with “chaos” and “stability” with “authoritarianism.”¹⁴ If economic, environmental, or scientific data also contain politically expedient biases, China’s data advantage may be unreliable.

Still, these risks are secondary to the system’s core function: to ensure that AI serves both China’s economic ascent and the Party’s political supremacy. Data is the hinge between economic development and authoritarian control, and it is through data that China’s ideological governance model is operationalized in the digital age.

VII. Limits of Central Planning: Bureaucratic Tensions & Bias

China’s AI governance framework is shaped by a fragmented yet centralized architecture, characterized by overlapping roles, institutional rivalries, and regulatory contradictions.¹⁵ While the CPC retains centralized ideological and strategic control, the execution of AI policy is distributed across multiple ministries and levels of government, each with distinct mandates and incentives.

At the central level, the CAC oversees data regulation and ideological compliance, especially concerning algorithmic content and data sovereignty. However, it shares responsibility with the NDB/NDA, and the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology (MIIT) leads the development and promotion of AI industries and technical standards. Meanwhile, the MPS drives AI integration into surveillance and internal security systems, while national research laboratories and institutions (e.g., CAS, CICT, CETC) act as innovation and application nodes.

These myriad roles are frequently in tension. Regulatory fragmentation manifests in conflicts over jurisdiction, particularly between CAC’s emphasis on cybersecurity and data control and MIIT’s interest in industrial growth and AI innovation. For example, while MIIT supports open

¹³ Kaufman, Arthur. In China Digital Times, Database Points to China’s Growing Use of A.I. for Online Surveillance and Censorship
<https://chinadigitaltimes.net/2025/03/database-points-to-chinas-growing-use-of-a-i-for-online-surveillance-and-censorship>

¹⁴ Knight, Will. In Wired Magazine, How Censorship Can Influence Artificial Intelligence,
<https://www.wired.com/story/how-censorship-can-influence-artificial-intelligence>

¹⁵ Elswah, Mona & Philip N. Howard. State Power 2.0: Authoritarian Innovations in China’s Information Ecosystem. Journal of Democracy, 2020.

data-sharing to spur AI development, CAC imposes stringent restrictions on cross-border data flows and model outputs, creating bottlenecks for research and application.

These contradictions are compounded by China's dual-track governance structure. The kuai-kuai (块块) system of horizontal governance empowers provincial and municipal governments to implement localized AI initiatives, often resulting in innovative pilot projects and city-level experimentation. Conversely, the vertical tiao-tiao (条条) system enables ministries to operate independently, which can cause disjointed implementation, redundant infrastructure, and inconsistent standards across jurisdictions. These systems can also interfere with one another.

Institutional rivalries further complicate coordination. Agencies compete for budgetary authority, project leadership, and influence over standard-setting. For instance, the CAC and MIIT have clashed over who has ultimate authority over AI ethics regulation. Similarly, the Ministry of Education (MOE) and Ministry of Science and Technology (MOST) have overlapping responsibilities in AI talent development, leading to fragmented educational pipelines and duplicated funding.

Ideological mandates often override technical considerations, particularly when AI outputs intersect with public opinion, political discourse, or content moderation. In 2023, CAC regulations explicitly required AI-generated content to reflect Core Socialist Values¹⁶ and assigned firms legal responsibility to align their output with Party doctrine. This has placed additional pressure on private companies and labs, stifling experimentation and delaying model deployment. It has also created political bias in AI outputs and calls into question the reliability of the data being used to train the AI models.

Finally, local governments—tasked with implementing national AI objectives—face challenges of uneven technical capacity, funding shortfalls, and policy ambiguity. Provincial disparities in computing resources, data governance maturity, and administrative competence create friction in building a unified AI ecosystem. As a result, national-level objectives often face inconsistencies, delays, or outright reinterpretation at the local level.

VIII. Conclusion

China's artificial intelligence program is centrally planned and ideologically engineered through layers of national policy, and implemented by a coordinated collaboration among government, SOEs, private tech companies, academia, and the military. This is in stark contrast to the United States' unregulated AI ecosystem, led by private tech companies and university researchers.

¹⁶ Nolan, Beatrice. In Business Insider, Beijing appears to be demanding that Chinese AI models have “socialist values.”

<https://www.businessinsider.com/china-government-ai-tech-chatbots-censorship-socialist-values-ccp-2024-7>

Central planning has allowed China to rapidly develop its sovereign technology and expand its global influence while maintaining (and vastly expanding) the political control of the CPC. While this control limits some aspects of creativity, invites political favoritism, and encourages bias in AI outputs and even data, it has made China a global leader in AI and a peer competitor with the US.

Appendix

Table 1. Key Chinese Government Policies and Institutional Actors Responsible for Driving AI Development

To support the layered analysis presented in this report, the following table provides a chronological list of key Chinese government policies and the institutional actors responsible for driving AI development. This timeline illustrates how abstract ideological commitments, such as national rejuvenation, governance modernization, and tech self-reliance, have been systematically translated into concrete regulatory actions, funding streams, and bureaucratic mandates. Rather than treating AI as a standalone issue, these policies embed it within a broader strategy of digital governance and state modernization. By aligning ideological vision with administrative execution, the Chinese Communist Party has constructed a multi-decade, multi-agency architecture that advances its AI ambitions across civilian, commercial, and military domains. The table serves as a detailed evidentiary backbone for understanding how China's approach to AI has evolved over time and why it remains uniquely centralized and strategic in global comparison.

Central Government Policy Driver	Year	Primary Institutional Actor(s)	Function / Role in AI	Significant Impacts
Outline for National Scientific and Technological Development (1991–2000) (国家科学技术发展十年规划纲要)	1991	Deng Xiaoping, Jiang Zemin, China State Council, State Science and Technology Commission	Institutionalized policies of Deng & Jiang toward domestic tech development post Tiananmen & Gulf War	Focused research projects like 863 and Torch program on internet, IT infrastructure, semiconductors
Socialism with Chinese Characteristics (中国特色社会主义市场经济)	1992	Jiang Zemin, CPC Central Committee, National Development and 1991 Reform Commission (NDRC)	Allows market-driven innovation in tech but with heavy state support and de-risking of indigenous research	Lays groundwork for SOE-aligned innovation, foreign joint ventures and adoption of international tech

Central Government Policy Driver	Year	Primary Institutional Actor(s)	Function / Role in AI	Significant Impacts
Strategy for the Revitalization of the Nation through Science and Education (科教兴国战略)	1995	Jiang Zemin, CPC Central Committee, China State Council, Ministry of Science and Technology (MOST)	Major national investments in research universities, high-tech industrial parks, basic research	211 Project for research universities, 973 Project to fund basic research, expansion of 863 Project in applied tech
Decision on Technological Innovation (技术创新决定)	1998	Jiang Zemin, CPC Central Committee, China State Council	Strengthening of national champions and launch of new applied enterprises	Builds “产学研” – an enterprise-university-research collaboration in computing
Three Represents (三个代表)	2000	Jiang Zemin, CPC Central Committee	Pivots the CPC away from Marxist class struggle into business, tech, and mass social control	Fundamental groundwork for elite coordination among government, business and academia in AI
Import–Digest–Absorb–Re-Innovate (引进–消化–吸收–再创新)	2006	Hu Jintao, State Council, MOST, NDRC	Leverage foreign investment and joint ventures to rapidly advance Chinese tech companies	Allows for massive tech transfer and indigenous innovation, leapfrogging of foreign technology

Central Government Policy Driver	Year	Primary Institutional Actor(s)	Function / Role in AI	Significant Impacts
Military-Civil Fusion (军民融合)	2007, 2015	Under Hu Jintao: Central Military Commission (CMC) PLA, MOST, Ministry of Industry and Information Technology (MIIT) Under Xi Jinping: Central Military-Civil Fusion Development Commission	Dual-use technology sharing; integrated civilian and military technology ecosystems	AI for autonomous weapons, ISR, defense-startup collaboration
Strategic Emerging Industries Initiative (战略性新兴产业)	2010	State Council, MOST, MIIT, NDRC	Identify key future sectors (including AI, biotech, clean energy) for prioritized investment	First time AI is officially included in a “strategic” category, becoming the precursor to MIC2025 and NGAIDP
National Rejuvenation/ “China Dream” (民族复兴)	2012	Xi Jinping/CPC Central Committee, CPC Propaganda Department	Ideological unifier; civilizational framing of tech progress	Justifies massive state-led AI push to surpass U.S. leadership
Governance Modernization (国家治理现代化)	2013	State Council, Ministry of Public Security (MPS), MIIT, MOST, Cyberspace Administration of China (CAC)	Digitally enhance government efficiency	AI courts, facial recognition, city governance systems
Comprehensive National Security (国家安全观)	2014	Central National Security Commission, MPS, CAC, PLA, MSS (Ministry of State Security)	Broad definition of security (including cyber, data, AI)	Surveillance AI, data localization laws, secure AI infrastructure

Central Government Policy Driver	Year	Primary Institutional Actor(s)	Function / Role in AI	Significant Impacts
Made in China 2025 (中国制造2025)	2015	State Council	Reduce reliance on foreign tech and become a global leader in advanced manufacturing	Promotes AI, robotics, chips, and smart manufacturing as national priorities
Internet Plus Initiative (互联网+)	2015	State Council, NDRC (National Development and Reform Commission), MIIT, CAC	Digitize traditional industries via AI, Big Data, and cloud computing	Catalyzes AI adoption in industrial, healthcare, agriculture, and service sectors
National Data Strategy (国家大数据战略)	2017	State Council, NDRC, MIIT, CAC, National Data Administration/ Bureau (NDA/NDB)	Institutionalize data as a strategic economic resource	Enables AI innovation through centralized data exchanges and mandatory platform data-sharing
New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan (新一代人工智能发展规划的通知)	2017	State Council	Centralized coordination of AI development to ensure socialism is built in, as well as commercial viability and global reach for AI leadership by 2030	Establishes “national champion” corporations in select industries (Huawei, ZTE, Tencent, SMIC, iFlytek)
China Standards 2035 (中国标准2035)	2018	Standardization Administration of China (SAC), Chinese Academy of Engineering (CAE).	Technical-industrial blueprint to implement tech leadership and regulatory influence	Core to the subsequent Vision 2035 policy, positioning China for global leadership

Central Government Policy Driver	Year	Primary Institutional Actor(s)	Function / Role in AI	Significant Impacts
AI Governance w/ Chinese Characteristics (中国特色人工智能治理观)	2019	MOST, CAC, MIIT, SAC	Ethics oversight and social control of AI	Algorithmic regulation, LLM content rules, facial recognition bans
Tech Self-Reliance (科技自立自强)	2020	CPC Leading Group on S&T, Standing Committee, MOST, NDRC, (NDA/NDB)	Innovation capacity, domestic substitution	AI chips, indigenous algorithms, domestic LLMs
Vision 2035 Blueprint (远景目标2035)	2021	CPC Central Committee, State Council	Macro-strategy for high-level technological independence and CPC-led digital governance model as a global alternative to liberal-democratic digital norms	Positions AI as foundational to social governance, military modernization, and economic competitiveness
Data Security Law (数据安全法)	2021	Standing Committee (NPC), CAC, MPS, MIIT	Regulates data in alignment with national security and sovereignty goals	Establishes data as factor of production, mandates local servers and imposes legal liabilities on companies
Plan for the Overall Layout of Building a Digital China (数字中国建设整体布局规划)	2023	CPC Central Committee, State Council	Build digital infrastructure, economy, government, culture, environment	Smart Cities, cloud platforms, AI in public services

Table 2: Key Social Governance Policies Enabling China’s AI Development

Table 2 highlights the evolving role of social governance policies in enabling and accelerating China’s AI development. These initiatives reflect how artificial intelligence has gradually shifted from an auxiliary tool to an essential feature of the Chinese Communist Party’s approach to domestic control, surveillance, and digital governance. From early infrastructure projects like Golden Shield and Skynet, to modern initiatives such as Smart Cities and AI-enabled Social Governance, the table tracks how AI applications have been deeply embedded in the Party’s pursuit of social stability, ideological control, and civilizational rejuvenation. By aligning surveillance, censorship, and population management goals with technical innovation, these social policies provide not only training data but also real-world operational environments for China’s AI systems. This list underscores a central argument of this report: China’s AI strategy is not isolated, it is structurally integrated with broader policies of digital authoritarianism, national security, and state-driven modernization.

Policy Name (English and Chinese)	Year	Purpose	AI Impact
Golden Shield Project (金盾工程)	2003	Establishes nationwide surveillance infrastructure, using human censors and the “Great Firewall” to monitor and control internet activities	Integrates databases and surveillance systems that will provide data for AI and early applications
Harmonious Socialist Society (和谐社会)	2004	Hu Jintao’s initiative to address social inequalities and tensions due to rapid economic growth and globalization over the previous two decades. Broad policy goals to fix issues such as income disparities, environmental degradation, and corruption	Central driving policy for online surveillance and censorship

Policy Name (English and Chinese)	Year	Purpose	AI Impact
Skynet (天网工程)	2005	Massive surveillance network of cameras across China. Integrates data from public security databases for real-time tracking and identification	Drives facial recognition and AI algorithms to monitor public spaces & deter crime
Military-Civil Fusion (军民融合)	2007	Integrates civilian and military technology ecosystems	Accelerates dual-use AI applications, especially in autonomous systems, surveillance, and command and control
National Rejuvenation / “China Dream” (民族复兴)	2012	Ideological unifier; civilizational framing of tech progress	Justifies massive state-led AI push to surpass U.S. leadership, unites tech and social policies
Sharp Eyes Project (雪亮工程)	2013	Extends surveillance into rural areas, integrates public and private feeds, and lets residents monitor feeds & report	Provides massive data of video footage and crowd-sourced monitoring to train AI
Belt and Road Initiative (一带一路)	2013 (~2017 emphasis)	Expand China’s global economic and digital influence	Export of AI surveillance, smart cities, and digital infrastructure through the Digital Silk Road
Grid-Style Social Management (网格化社会管理)	2015 (nationally)	Grid-based urban surveillance blocks, with local personnel to monitor and report on residents' activities	Combines traditional community surveillance with new technologies, creating a rich dataset for future AI applications
Internet Plus Initiative (互联网+)	2015	Digitize traditional industries via AI, Big Data, and cloud computing	Catalyzes AI adoption in industrial, healthcare, agriculture, and service sectors

Policy Name (English and Chinese)	Year	Purpose	AI Impact
National Informatization Strategy (国家信息化发展战略纲要)	2016	Guide development of a digital economy and smart society	Lays out groundwork for Smart Cities, IoT, and AI-powered governance, tying into the 13 th FYP and AIDP
Promoting the Healthy Development of the AI Industry (关于促进人工智能产业健康发展的指导意见)	2017	Provide operational roadmap for AI industry scaling	Sectoral AI plans for manufacturing, healthcare, finance, etc.; first practical guide for AI applications and industrial upgrades
New Generation Artificial Intelligence Development Plan (新一代人工智能发展规划)	2017	Make China a global AI leader by 2030	Central roadmap for AI advancement in theory, tech, ethics, and industry
National Data Strategy (国家大数据战略)	2017	Institutionalize data as a strategic economic resource	Enables AI innovation through centralized data exchanges and mandatory platform data-sharing
AI Governance w/ Chinese Characteristics (中国特色人工智能治理观)	2019	Ethical oversight and social control of AI	Algorithmic regulation, LLM content rules, facial recognition bans
AI-Enabled Social Governance Plans (人工智能+社会治理)	2018 to present	Apply AI in public security, urban planning, social services	Surveillance tech, predictive policing, and citizen scoring systems; operationalized in Smart City and Safe City programs

Policy Name (English and Chinese)	Year	Purpose	AI Impact
China Standards 2035 (中国标准2035)	Draft 2020	Shape global standards in AI, 5G, IoT, and other frontier technologies	Ensures China's AI norms and standards influence global governance
AI Ethics & Governance Guidelines (人工智能伦理治理准则)	2019	Guide responsible and controllable AI development	Promotes AI fairness, transparency, and safety (e.g., algorithm regulation)
Vision 2035 Blueprint (远景目标2035)	2021	Macro-strategy for high-level technological independence and CPC-led digital governance model as a global alternative to liberal-democratic digital norms	Positions AI as foundational to social governance, military modernization, and economic competitiveness